I am standing at mid-on. Steve Harmison has the ball. He caused so many problems in England – scaring and scarring the top order, showing them that England could lay gloves on them – that we all expect him to do the same here. They say that ‘everyone has a plan until you get punched in the face’. Facing Harmison is the definition of that. There’s a sense that, as in 2005, whatever he does now will in some way indicate the direction of the whole series from here. He begins to run in and – with 42,000 packed into the Gabba and televisions on through the night across the whole of England – I start to walk in alongside him. When he releases, for a millisecond I feel like the ball might have been edged because, unthinkably, it has ended up straight in the hands of Freddie at second slip. It takes me a moment to process what has happened. He’s bowled it straight there, the biggest wide I have ever seen in professional cricket. It would have been wide on the next pitch. Freddie has got rid of the ball so quickly, it’s as if he is trying to pretend it didn’t happen at all. It’s too late, everyone has seen. Everyone knows.

Some series have the whole thing, the months of cricket to come, just rolled into its very first micro-event. It was all there. The whole of 2005 wiped out as if it were a dream, in one ball. Playing in Australia can do that to you. Australia end the day 346-3. We lose the series 5-0. I didn’t bowl well. It was the same story again. Like all my previous experiences against Australia in Australia, whether that be watching on television in Burnley, sighing into the void, or the heckling of my nameless shirt at the MCG, or here, leaving versed in all the questions but with none of the answers, scratching our heads about what needed to be done to even get close.